Float First: Free Swimming and Water-Safety Lessons for Grades 2 to 4 Begin in November

Saeng Arun Primary School, Phitsanulok · Parent Newsletter Issue 2026/07 · Published 1 October 2026

Phitsanulok, 1 October 2026 – Every pupil in Grades 2, 3 and 4 at Saeng Arun Primary School will take part in Float First, a new ten-week swimming and water-safety programme, during the second semester. Lessons take place at the Bueng Phra Aquatic Centre, about 6 kilometres from the school, and start on Tuesday 10 November 2026.

1. Why the school is starting Float First

Many of our families live close to the Nan River and the irrigation canals east of Bueng Phra, and the floods of September 2025 reached two of the village roads our pupils use every day. In June 2026 our physical education team ran a simple water-confidence check with 238 pupils in Grades 2 to 4. Only 92 of them could float on their back for 30 seconds without help, and 54 had never been in water deeper than their waist. The school board decided that learning to float and to call for help is as basic a skill as reading and road safety.

"We do not expect every child to become a strong swimmer in ten weeks," said Director Nanthawan Sirikhet. "We want every child to know how to stay on the surface, how to help a friend without jumping in, and when to stay away from the water altogether."

2. Who takes part and what it costs

All pupils in Grades 2, 3 and 4 are included in Float First as part of the physical education timetable. Grade 1 pupils are not included this year; a shorter pilot for Grade 1 is planned for the first semester of 2027. Grade 5 and 6 pupils are not part of the weekly lessons, but Grade 5 pupils who took part in the 2025 trial and did not pass its final swim check may join the Saturday catch-up group described in section 7.

Lessons, instructors and the school bus are free for families. The programme is funded by a grant of 186,000 baht from the Nan Riverbank Community Fund and by the Saeng Arun Parents' Association. Families only pay for the pupil kit:

- Float First kit (swimming cap, mesh bag and name tag): 120 baht, paid to the class teacher together with the consent form. Families who hold a school fee waiver receive the kit free of charge.
- Swimwear: families provide their own. Plain, close-fitting swimwear is required; T-shirts, jeans and football shorts are not allowed in the pool.
- Replacement cap: 40 baht if a cap is lost or damaged.

Parents of last year's Grade 4 pupils may remember the trial lessons at a private pool in 2025, which cost 350 baht per child for six sessions. That fee no longer applies.

3. Timetable and transport

Each grade has one lesson per week on a fixed day, for ten sessions in total:

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- Grade 2: Tuesdays, from 10 November 2026.
- Grade 3: Wednesdays, from 11 November 2026.
- Grade 4: Thursdays, from 12 November 2026.

Sessions run weekly until the week of 22 December 2026, pause for the New Year break, and continue in the weeks of 5, 12 and 19 January 2027. The final session in the week of 19 January is the assessment session. Because Thursday 10 December 2026 is a public holiday, the Grade 4 session for that week moves to Friday 11 December.

The school bus leaves from Gate 2 (the Rim Khlong Road gate) at 13:10 and returns to Gate 2 at 15:20. Each session lasts 90 minutes at the centre, of which 45 minutes are spent in the water; the remaining time is for changing, a short safety talk on the poolside and a head count. Two teachers travel on every bus. Parents who collect their children at 15:20 should wait at Gate 2, not at the main gate, because the main gate car park is closed to cars between 15:00 and 15:45.

4. Consent forms and health questions

Every pupil needs a signed Float First consent form (form F-07, sent home in the blue folder this week) and the one-page health questionnaire. Both must reach the class teacher by Friday 23 October 2026. Pupils whose forms have not arrived by that date cannot travel to the pool and will stay at school for a supervised reading session in the library until their forms are received.

The school nurse, Ratchanee Inthapan, reviews every health questionnaire. A doctor's note confirming that the child may swim is required before the first session for pupils with epilepsy, a heart condition, ear grommets (ventilation tubes) or a perforated eardrum. Asthma does not require a doctor's note, but a child with asthma must bring their reliever inhaler in the mesh bag every week; without it the child may not enter the water that day.

Illness on the day

Parents should keep the child out of the water, and tell the class teacher in the morning, if the child has a fever, vomiting or diarrhoea in the previous 48 hours, an open wound or a skin infection, or conjunctivitis (red, sticky eyes). A child who has had an ear infection in the last 7 days also sits out, even if they feel well. Children who sit out still travel with the class and take part in the poolside safety talk, unless they have a fever, in which case they stay at school.

> **Note.** A child who sits out for health reasons is not marked absent for the purpose of the certificate (see section 7) if the parent informed the class teacher by 08:30 on the day.

5. Safety at the pool

All lessons are taught by instructors from the Bueng Phra Aquatic Centre who hold a current lifesaving qualification, and one lifeguard watches the teaching area at all times. Pupils are grouped by ability using cap colours, and the number of children per instructor depends on the group:

- Red cap: cannot yet float without help. At most 6 pupils per instructor, in water no deeper than 0.9 metres.

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- Yellow cap: can float on the back for 30 seconds but cannot yet swim 15 metres. At most 8 pupils per instructor, in the 1.1-metre section.
- Green cap: can swim 15 metres without stopping. At most 10 pupils per instructor, and may use the 1.4-metre section with an instructor in the water.

Every child starts in a red cap in the first session and moves up after the instructor checks them. Pupils may not move to a deeper section on their own, even if a friend is there. Teachers do a head count when pupils enter the water, every 15 minutes during the lesson and again when they leave.

6. What pupils will learn

The programme follows the "Float, Shout, Reach" approach. Pupils learn to float on their back and their front, to tread water, to turn towards the side and hold on, and to shout and wave for help. They also practise helping a friend from the side by reaching with a pole or throwing a floating object, and they learn the rule that children never jump in to rescue someone. Two short classroom lessons in December cover flooded roads and canal edges.

At the assessment session in the week of 19 January 2027, pupils who can float for 2 minutes, tread water for 30 seconds and swim 10 metres to the side receive the Float First Certificate. Pupils who also swim 25 metres without stopping receive the Float First Gold badge in addition to the certificate. Results are sent home with the semester report.

7. Missed sessions, rain and the Saturday catch-up group

To receive the certificate, a pupil must attend at least 8 of the 10 sessions as well as the assessment. A pupil who misses 3 or more sessions is not assessed in January, but may finish the programme in the Saturday catch-up group, which meets at the centre on 30 January and 6 February 2027 from 09:00 to 11:00. Parents bring their child to the centre for these Saturday sessions, as there is no school bus. Catch-up pupils who pass the checks on 6 February receive the certificate in the same way.

If an official thunderstorm warning is issued for Mueang Phitsanulok, or lightning is seen near the centre, the session is cancelled. The school will post a cancellation in the class LINE group by 11:30 on the day. A cancelled session does not count as a missed session: it is replaced in the reserve week of 26 January 2027, on the same weekday as usual. If a pupil cannot attend the replacement session, it does count as missed.

8. Contacts

- Programme questions, timetable and catch-up places: Teerapong Khamwilai, PE Coordinator, Room B-104, telephone 055 214 377 (school hours).
- Health questionnaire and doctor's notes: Ratchanee Inthapan, School Nurse, Health Room next to the canteen.
- Kit payments and fee waivers: the school office, Building A, ground floor, Monday to Friday 08:00 to 16:00.

Parents may watch a lesson from the spectator seats after registering at the centre reception.

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